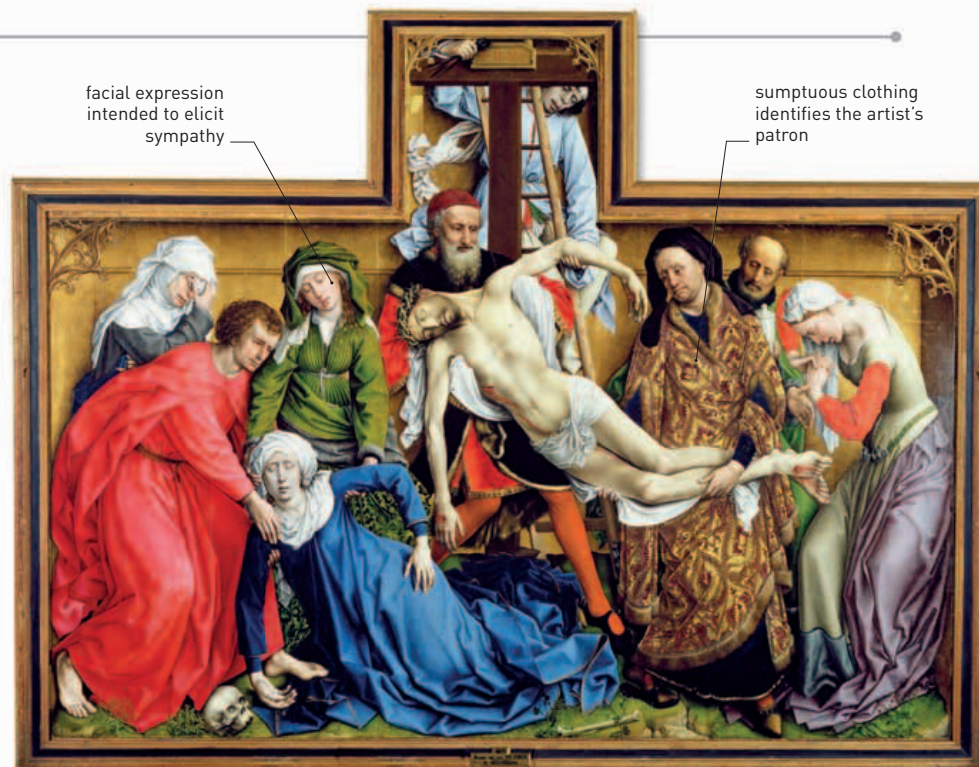




Processional cross
15th century • ITALY
The wealth of the Italian Catholic Church is expressed by this cross, made of gold, silver, and enamel, and paraded on religious holidays.



facial expression
intended to elicit
sympathy

sumptuous clothing
identifies the artist's
patron



Venetian gold ducat
16th century • ITALY
This gold coin depicts the Doge of Venice (right) receiving the city's banner from a dominating St. Mark the Evangelist.

The Descent from the Cross
c. 1435 • NETHERLANDS
This painting by Rogier van der Weyden (c. 1399–1464) exemplifies Flemish assimilation of the Renaissance move toward idealization of faces and figures.

THE RENAISSANCE

A REBIRTH OF EUROPEAN CULTURE INSPIRED BY ANCIENT GREECE AND ROME

A thousand years after the Roman Empire's collapse, scholars in Florence, Italy, arrived at a renewed understanding of the art, architecture, and literature of the classical period, sparking a cultural revolution.

In the 14th century, trade among European states increased and Florence, as a banking and commercial center—eventually under Medici control—developed a class of wealthy, educated individuals who became patrons of artists and thinkers. If Florence stood initially at the forefront of these artistic and intellectual developments, by the 16th century, the lead had passed to Papal Rome and Venice.



floor plan
under dome

lantern lets
in light and air

Florence Cathedral's dome
15th century • ITALY
The octagonal cathedral dome by Filippo Brunelleschi (1377–1446) consists of three parts, with the innermost visible from inside the building, as shown by this 19th-century engraving.

inner brick dome
supports light roof

Mona Lisa
1503–06 • ITALY
Also known as *La Gioconda*, this enigmatic painting by Leonardo da Vinci (1452–1519) is the most famous Renaissance work and the world's best-known painting.



beard demonstrates
sculptor's skill

larger than
life-size figure
(8.33 ft/2.54 m high)

Figure of Moses
c. 1515 • ITALY
Sculpted by Michelangelo (1475–1564) for the tomb of Pope Julius II, this statue now stands in the Church of San Pietro in Vincoli, Rome.



horns represent
light rays